out, the police rushed in, water cannons had to be used. Kejriwal had got his breaking news TV moment .

Right through 2012–13, there were several such moments when Kejriwal simply outsmarted his more experienced political rivals. When the municipal authorities tore down AAP posters and banners, he got auto rickshaws to carry his political message or volunteers to hold up banners at traffic signals and flyovers. When the Delhi gang rape in December 2012 led to street protests, Kejriwal was the first politician to join the protestors and call for the Delhi police commissioner's removal. The AAP got 10 lakh citizen letters protesting the inflated power and water bills, and handed them over to chief minister Sheila Dikshit. Kejriwal set the agenda; the national parties were forced to follow in his wake.

The aim was always to create the kind of news which would excite the national media and keep the AAP visible at all times. An SMS joke ran as follows: The Congress and BJP tell Kejriwal, 'We have money, muscle, men, what do you have?' Kejriwal replies, *'Mere paas media hai!'* (I have the media with me.)

A good example of how the party operated was the AAP 'exposé' on Robert Vadra, Sonia Gandhi's son-in-law. An *Economic Times* report had mentioned Vadra's land deals in 2011 but the story had been quickly buried. An investigative journalist had taken the documents to a senior BJP leader, asking him to take it up in Parliament. But the documents never saw the light of day. Tired of waiting, the journalist took the papers to Kejriwal and lawyer-activist Prashant Bhushan. They held a press conference almost right away and got mileage across the media. A few weeks later, in an attempt to appear even-handed, they did another 'exposé', this time on Gadkari's alleged links with an irrigation scam.

Kejriwal was conscious of using the media as an ally. Like Modi, Kejriwal was at ease in front of a camera and never short of a strong sound bite. Some of the AAP leader's closest advisers were journalists. One of my own colleagues, Ashutosh, who edited our Hindi channel IBN 7, joined AAP. 'He is the cleverest politician since Mahatma Gandhi!' claimed Ashutosh, sounding like a complete fanboy.